Al Qaeda, which the Pakistani Taliban had proven with their activities in FATA, Swat and the rest of Pakistan.

The US concern was about the Al Qaeda in FATA. Initially, it viewed TTP as the insurgents focused on Pakistan. On the other hand, Pakistan failed to perceive the presence of Al Qaeda in FATA, as it was not targeting Pakistan. But soon both Pakistan and the US realised the nexus between the two and the lethality of the combination that had expanded its nature and scope of operation. The then US President Obama stated loud and clear that 'Multiple intelligence estimates have warned that Al Qaeda is actively planning attacks on the US homeland from its safe heavens in Pakistan'.

He added that 'The single greatest threat to their (US & Pakistan) interests comes from al-Qaeda and its extremist allies. That is why we must stand together'.

He then warned that Pakistan would be held responsible for its potential failure to act against terrorism on its soil (*The Nation*, 2009).

He further asserted that 'The situation is increasingly perilous. The world cannot afford the price that will come due if Afghanistan slides back into chaos or al-Qaeda operates unchecked' (*The Nation*, 2009).

These statements mirrored four US concerns, which have become one big concern for Pakistan: first, Al Qaeda is planning a big attack on the US from the Pakistani soil; secondly, its local allies are a threat to the US and Pakistan and that the latter could become a failed state; thirdly, Pakistan would be held responsible if these two (TTP and Al Qaeda) would carry out such attacks on the US and fourthly, these elements in FATA were adversely affecting US efforts in Afghanistan.

Owing to its elusive nature, Al Qaeda was not visible, and as of the writing of this paper, no spectacular attack, as feared by the US, has taken place. The fact remained that Al Qaeda had no specific permanent base or particular country where it belonged. It had cells almost in 40 countries of the world (Ken & Dunne, 2002). Its rules of engagement were also exceptional, as it never engaged in a direct-armed conflict, battle or guerrilla war. It struck surreptitiously and snaked away, leaving behind trails, enough to reveal its imprints but too less to discern its operational plans and preparations. This strategy prevented disruption of its manpower and command and control structure. Its structure was fragmented and layered in sub-groups, often formed on the basis of nationalities, headed by the respective nationals. It was mercurial in